he also admitted that half the team had actually been in the wrong place at the same time. It was as close as I was going to get to an admission that singling me out for criticism in the dressing room that afternoon hadn't been fair.

At any other point in my career as a United player, we'd have called it quits there and then. A month later, it would have seemed as if nothing had ever happened. I didn't realize, though, in the days after that Arsenal game, what I know now: the boss and I had already reached a point where there was going to be no turning back. Had Alex Ferguson already made up his mind about David Beckham back then? Decided he didn't want me at the club any longer? Even if he had, I bet that it didn't have him any better prepared than I was for how things would turn out over the coming six months.